

The Interpretation OF YARNS

Threads and voices interweave as experts meet in the Pink City to stitch together the nation's living traditions

| By Damayanti Datta |

Can textiles tell stories? In a new effort to understand identity and culture, experts all over the world are studying textile art, including in India, and literally spinning a new yarn. Siyahi—a team of writers, editors, researchers and publishers—is at the forefront of the movement which arranged the *Mantles of Myth: The Narrative of Indian Textiles*, a celebration of Indian textiles held in Jaipur. The congregation brought together sociologists and economists, artisans and artists, fashion designers and authors, to unravel the “stories” of cultures and communities through textiles. “It is important to study and preserve the traditions that created our textiles because they are often the only surviving evidence of very many ways of life not documented in any other manner,” says Mita Kapoor, an ebullient journalist-literary agent and CEO of Siyahi, “especially, a large swathe of everyday life across the country—of underprivileged sections and of women.”

Among the invitees was Jasleen Dhamija, former professor of living cultural traditions at the University of Minnesota, US, now based in Delhi, who has devoted her life to deciphering tales on textiles. “We often talk of life and of stories as spun-threads, knitted into the fabric of communities or history,” she says. “For textile decoders, the twisted yarn tells the story

of life.” And decoders from across the world came together at the Garden retreat of the Thakurs of Diggi. Outside, it looked like a huge family wedding. Cars jammed the narrow entrance of the haveli, red banners fluttered in the wind, white-draped tables dotting the manicured lawns promised sumptuous meals, turban-clad chaiwallahs moved around with brass tea pots, piles of antique textiles vied with pyramids of handwoven craft, hundreds of people thronged the courtyards, and the royal ladies of Diggi, decked out in nose rings and forehead pendants, greeted guests with folded hands. Then, just to shatter the illusion, a voice would boom on the microphone: “Adam and Eve were cast out of Eden when they became aware of their nakedness.”

From Adam to Rama, Eve to Sita, Devdutt Pattanaik set the tone of the festival. “Textile, like a literary text, reflects shifts in cultures and values through colours, patterns, and textures,” says the medic-turned-mythologist. Clothing in our mythology, Pattanaik explains, transforms the pelt-clad hermit, Shiva, into the silk-robed householder, Vishnu. Similarly, the Puranic goddess, Shakti, alternates between a naked and ferocious Kali and a bedecked and bejewelled Gauri—symbolising the needs and demands of the times. “The disrobing of Draupadi in Mahabharata symbolises the end of

civilisation,” he says “but when the same Krishna, who saves Draupadi, steals the clothes of gopis, the implication is that the Lord wishes to see humanity in its true self, without guise.” Rama wore bark during his exile, but Sita was sent out in silken robes, signalling the virtues—right conduct and right living.

Tales of Phulkari, the embroidered “garden of flowers” from Punjab, bring to life the richness of women's lives. “These glorious wraps of everyday witnessed all rites of passage—



Colour Play

Sudden red threads among yellow signify happiness: a birth or a marriage or a visit from a daughter



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—Jasleen Dhamija, scholar of living traditions, especially the Phulkari work of Punjab

